Customs Broker

A narrow role, on purpose. Declarations, and the shipment fields clearance depends on.

> Read `00-orientation.md` first.

What you hold

YOU CAN	YOU CANNOT
File and update a customs declaration	Create or book a shipment
Record duty paid	Cancel, complete or close one
Update shipments — dates, references, containers	Price an enquiry or send a quotation
Read every shipment in your branches	Add a rate card, agent or port
	Touch an invoice or a receipt

The role is deliberately narrow. You need the declaration and the shipment fields clearance depends on, and nothing else — which also means nothing else can go wrong under your account.

The customs screen

Operations → Customs. Declarations in clearance, **ordered by the window that closes first**.

That ordering is the feature. It is not newest-first and it is not by shipment reference: it is by which clearance deadline expires soonest, so the top of the list is where the next problem is.

Each row shows the shipment, the customer, the declaration number, when it was filed, when clearance is due, the broker, and the duty.

The counters at the top: **in clearance**, **held**, **released**, **inspection required**. Held and inspection are the two that mean somebody must do something today.

The declaration, stage by stage

STAGE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT MOVES IT ON
Not started	Nothing filed	Documents arrive
Waiting for documents	The file is short something	The missing document
Declaration filed	Lodged with the authority	Assessment, or an inspection order

STAGE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT MOVES IT ON
Assessed	Duty determined	Payment — recorded by you, Finance or the operations manager
Duty paid	Settled	Release, or an inspection
Inspection	Physical examination ordered	Release, or a hold
Held	Held by the authority	Re-inspection, or release
Released	Cleared to move	—

A declaration can be held from waiting-for-documents as well. A file short of a certificate long enough becomes a hold, and it looks exactly like a hold caused by the authority. The way to prevent it is to record the missing document as an exception on the shipment the day you notice it, not the day it becomes a hold.

Record the declaration number as soon as you have it. It is what everyone else in the office uses to ask the authority anything, and it is what makes the clearance auditable afterwards.

All of this is one dialog on the shipment — **Update customs**: the stage, the broker, the declaration type and number, the duty payable as assessed, the clear-by date the register sorts on, whether a physical inspection is required, and notes. Only the stages customs can actually move to next are accepted.

Before it is filed

Estimate duty, on the shipment, gives a landed cost before anything is lodged: goods value, freight and insurance against the tariff loaded under *Reference data → Tariff*, matched by the HS code on each cargo line, longest prefix first. It is an estimate, not an assessment — the screen says so — and both are kept, so the gap between them can be measured. Lines with no HS code are left out unless you choose to apply the GCC general rate to them, which is off by default because 5% on a code the tariff has no row for is a guess that looks researched.

The **Customs declaration pack** is one of the documents the shipment can issue from its bill parties and cargo lines — what you would otherwise retype into the authority's system. Preview it in either language from **Issue and preview**; issuing it is the coordinator's.

Free time is running while you are working

Every day a container sits in clearance is a day against its free time. Demurrage, detention and storage clocks run against the carrier's free days and **write their own charge lines** when the free days run out.

Nobody has to notice, which cuts both ways: nobody has to notice, and nobody does. The dashboard shows the total accruing across the branch, and the shipment shows free days, chargeable days and the per-diem rate.

The dates that stop clocks are yours to enter promptly. Each clock under *Free time* on the shipment has a start and an **Ends** date, and the end date is what stops the accrual — charged days stay:

THE BOX	STOPS	IF YOU LEAVE IT LATE
Gated out of the terminal	Demurrage	The charge keeps accruing on paper after the box has left

THE BOX	STOPS	IF YOU LEAVE IT LATE
Empty returned to the line	Detention	A detention clock that never stops — a wrong charge, and an argument with the customer you will lose

Enter them on the day. Not at the end of the week.

Exceptions

When clearance goes wrong — a hold, an inspection, a document that has not come, a discrepancy in the declared value — **raise an exception on the shipment**.

Give it a severity, an owner and a due date, and the cost impact if there is one. It appears on the operations board, oldest first, and it is how the rest of the office finds out without you telling each of them separately.

Raise it even when you expect to resolve it today. How often a lane, an agent or a commodity produces a hold is a pattern worth having, and it only exists if the short-lived ones were recorded too.

What this system does not do

It does not file declarations. You file where you file today — the authority's own system, your broker portal, an agent. This system records the declaration, its number, its status, the duty and the deadline, so that everyone else can see where clearance has got to without ringing you.

For Kuwait specifically, direct filing is **not planned**. Access runs through a long-standing concession that a supplier of this software has no route into, and that is the honest position rather than a roadmap item.

It does not assess duty. It estimates it, from the tariff your operations manager loads; what the authority determines on filing is what you record, and the two are kept side by side.

It does not receive authority status feeds. Every customs status change is entered by a person — you. Carrier milestone feeds are a different matter: your administrator can switch on carrier-direct tracking for Maersk, Hapag-Lloyd and CMA CGM under *Settings → Integrations*, with each carrier's own registration. Until that is done, vessel milestones are typed too.

Your day

WHEN	WHAT
First thing	The customs screen. It is already ordered by which deadline closes first.
First thing	Held and inspection counters — these need action today
On the day it happens	Gated out, empty returned
On the day you get it	Declaration number, duty assessed, release
As soon as you notice	An exception for every hold, inspection or missing document
Weekly	Arriving this week, on the dashboard — clearance you can prepare before it lands